were, how willing to accept a sponsor's logo, no matter how vile or how murderous or how anti-intellectual, and I suppose I must count that part of my university education.

I once represented my university at the Australian National Physics Competition. At the prize ceremony, the head of Physics at the Australian National University motioned to us and said, 'You are the cream of Australian physics.' I looked around and thought to myself, 'Christ Almighty, I hope he's wrong.' But I had a certainty, a covert certainty in that company, that my interest in quantum mechanics could do more than make the chancellor blush with pride. I shared the view with a handful of computer scientists around the world that quantum mechanics offered a methodology for understanding justice.

Let me explain. Quantum mechanics is not merely a description of how the small parts of the world operate – and operate together to create very large parts of our experience, the whole observable universe – it also constitutes a systematised way of thinking about physical phenomena. If you study it properly, it will train you how to think clearly. You might remember that my early experiments with computers made me realise the difference between saying 'I want the computer to count' and 'This is how you count.' Studying quantum mechanics was a bit like that. It taught me how to ask questions about the world in such a way that I left every option on the table, not prejudicing the outcome. You've probably seen TV journalists asking soft questions to politicians with whom they – or the boss of their network – are sympathetic. You know, like 'Have you always been motivated by a desire to serve your country?' or 'Can you explain how your spending cuts will help our economy?' Quantum mechanics doesn't involve questions like that. It teaches you to ask questions that might actually produce a useful answer, and over time it will enable you to organise your thoughts about the natural world. It shows you how to prove things through experiment, and how to take nothing for granted, no hypothesis, until it has been exposed to every test of cause and effect. After the end of the Crypto Wars, and my trial, I had decided that I had some unfinished business in this area. As I said, I wanted to try and pierce the fabric of reality, and, when it came to social action, take the skin off all our assumptions and see what was underneath. Advanced mathematics and quantum mechanics allowed for that.